

Defective Circumvention: Multiple Agree as Minimal Search

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Abstract: In this paper, I show that complex agreement interaction effects involving optional agreement, weak PCC effects with multiple subjects, and obligatory participant probing can all be accounted for under a system of conditional, sequential Multiple Agree as Minimal Search known as defective circumvention. Building on observations from Storment (2025b), I motivate the possibility of optional agreement with certain postverbal subjects within a single grammatical system in a variety of languages including English and Spanish. Within the same system, I explain how featural specifications of the relevant probes and goals involved in these Multiple Agree configurations can constrain the aforementioned optionality, thus leading to impossible or obligatory agreement scenarios. Regarding the impossible agreement scenarios, I show that Agree as Minimal Search is all that is necessary to account for a family of weak PCC effects in multiple subject constructions in colloquial English. This work contextualizes agreement optionality, multiple agreement, and PCC effects within a single framework based on a Minimalist formulation of Agree.

Keywords: defective circumvention, Multiple Agree, Minimal Search, PCC, optionality.

1 Introduction

In colloquial English, it is possible to optionally realize subject-verb phi-agreement in a variety of configurations (see Storment 2025b). We can identify a natural class of these constructions in which verbal morphology may optionally track phi-agreement with a postverbal third person plural argument DP when there is some kind of non-canonical deficient element in the structural subject (i.e., preverbal) position. This phenomenon is exemplified below in (1) with existential *there* sentences.

- (1) a. There were no problems with the analysis.
- b. There was no problems with the analysis.

While there certainly is a difference in register between the (a) and (b) sentences above, it is certainly true that a considerable share of the English-speaking world accepts both (a) and (b) as grammatical. The above alternation has been described elsewhere in the literature (Rochemont 1978; Sobin 1997; Munn 1999; Schütze 1999; López 2007; Deal 2009, a.o), although with the caveats that the singular agreement is only acceptable with the contracted form of the singular copula -*'s* (Sobin 1997, Deal 2009) or that singular agreement is only possible via first conjunct agreement with a DP coordinate structure associate (Munn 1999). It also has been pointed out that singular verbal agreement with a plural associate is only possible in existential *there* constructions with a copular verb (Rochemont 1978; Schütze 1999; Deal 2009). I demonstrate that all of these claims do not hold for many English speakers, and that what we indeed see is general agreement optionality in existential *there* sentences with a third person plural postverbal argument DP. To the degree that it has been discussed in the literature, the optionality in (1) has been treated as a kind of aberrant quirk of the existential construction, or as something that is easily explainable-away as dialectal variation or a change in progress. I reject these claims, showing that the agreement optionality naturally follows from the syntactic derivation of the configuration (and others like it) given a few basic Minimalist assumptions about the nature of argument structure and subject-verb agreement.

Using colloquial speech data collected online in both written and spoken form (corroborated elsewhere; e.g., Storment 2025b), I empirically support the claim that the alternation in (1) is a case of grammatical optionality for those speakers who have it: that is, they may freely alternate between an agreeing form and a non-agreeing form (Section 2). Syntactically, this optionality is implemented in terms of *defective circumvention* (Storment 2025b), in which an agreement probe can conditionally search again after having agreed with a defective goal and go on to agree with a further, non defective goal (Section 3.1). I explain the optionality that specifically comes about with third person plural postverbal argument DPs in English in terms of derivational constraints that result from general economy conditions in the grammar (Section 3.2). I then demonstrate that defective circumvention is sufficient to handle a variety of PCC-effects seen in multiple subject configurations in English and a variety of other Romance and Germanic languages, thus expanding the typology of phenomena that can be captured under this framework of conditional cyclic probing (Section 4). Section 5 concludes.

Ultimately, this work provides a novel framework for thinking about and modeling intraspeaker morphosyntactic optionality within a single set of operations (i.e., grammar) operating over a single set of featurally-defined elements (i.e., lexicon). A further major contribution of this work is its ability to explain complex agreement interaction phenomena within a system of Agree that effectively reduces to Minimal Search, thus reducing the number of computational formalisms and stipulations needed to sufficiently explain complex multiple agreement paradigms.

2 The alternation as agreement optionality

As mentioned in the Introduction, verbal morphology may optionally track phi-agreement with a postverbal third person plural argument DP when there is some kind of non-canonical deficient element (i.e., something other than a standard argument DP) in the structural subject (i.e., preverbal) position. Though exemplified with existential *there* sentences in (1), this phenomenon is not limited to existential clauses, nor is it limited to English. Here I motivate the existence of such alternations as cases of true intraspeaker optionality.

2.1 Singular agreement with a plural DP

Storment (2025b) systematically shows that third person singular verbal agreement is possible with a wide variety of third person plural postverbal argument DP “associates” and a wide variety of verbal predicates with existential *there* sentences. This claim is motivated with naturally-occurring data gathered *en masse* from native English speakers in the form of written and spoken utterances collected via the Internet, mainly through social media platforms such as Twitter, Facebook, and YouTube, which are increasingly being seen as valid sources of linguistic data (Kilgarriif & Grefenstette 2003; Schütze 2011; Wikström 2017; Collins 2023, a.o). I reproduce some of the examples here, understanding that third person plural verbal agreement is also acceptable in all of the following examples.

- (2) a. There is two teams playing. (Storment 2025b:186-7)
 b. There was cats in the garden but they didn’t wanna be friends.
 c. There was seats.
 d. And there was these things, these killer clowns, and they shot popcorn at us!
 e. There was both options available mate.

- (3) a. So there appears two routes. (Storment 2025b:167-9)
 b. Out of one, there arises two.
 c. There arrives two annual influxes of new area residents
 d. There comes seasons in life for plenty.
 e. What I mean when I say there lives two wolves inside me.

This alternation is quite commonly seen in other configurations involving a non-canonical structural subject and a postverbal argument DP. Storment (2025b) convincingly shows that this alternation appears in quotative and locative inversion derivations. I focus here on specificational copular clauses in which the preverbal structural subject is a *wh*-cleft or *th*-cleft (Percus 1997; Berg 1998; Heycock 2012; Lee 2016; Den Dikken 2017; Krapp López & Gravely 2024).

- (4) a. What I love most of all {is/are} beautiful men.
 b. The thing I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.

Crucially, when the third person plural DP is preverbal in both existential and specificational copular clauses, the agreement optionality disappears (or becomes pragmatically highly marked in the case of (7)).

- (5) a. There {is/are} no problems in this analysis.
 b. No problems {are/*is} present in this analysis.
- (6) a. There {has/have} arrived three men from across the sea.
 b. Three men {have/*has} arrived from across the sea.
- (7) a. All I want for Christmas {is/are} my two front teeth.
 b. My two front teeth {are/?is} all I want for Christmas.
- (8) a. The thing I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.
 b. Beautiful men {are/*is} the thing I love most in this world.

These agreement alternations are not limited to English, and can be seen in a variety of configurations crosslinguistically that all crucially involve a postverbal third person plural argument DP. The alternation is seen in dative experiencer subject constructions in several languages.

- (9) Nos encanta {-Ø/ -n} las películas de terror. (Spanish, Fernández-Serrano 2022:9)
 us.DAT love {-3sg/-3pl} the films of terror
 ‘We love horror movies.’
- (10) Henni {líkaði/ líkuðu} þeir. (Icelandic, Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008:260)
 her.DAT {like.3sg/like.3pl} they.NOM
 ‘She likes them.’

- (11) Nógvum kvinnum {dámar/ dáma} mannfólk (Faroese, Jónsson 2009:157)
 many.DAT women.DAT {like.3sg/like.3pl} men.ACC
 við eitt sindur av búki.
 with a bit of belly
 ‘Many women like slightly fat men.’

The same alternation is seen in existential constructions in multiple languages, as in English.

- (12) Hi ha {-Ø/ -n} tres cadires. (Catalan, Rigau 2005)
 there have {-3sg/-3pl} three chairs
 ‘There {is/are} three chairs.’
- (13) Hub{-o/ -ieron} dos hombres en la fiesta. (Spanish, Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008:326-7)
 had {-3sg/-3pl} two men in the party
 ‘There {was/were} two men at the party.’

This alternation is further possible with postverbal subjects of unaccusative verbs in certain Romance varieties.

- (14) Fech {-ou/ -aram} muitas fábricas. (Portuguese, Costa 2000:8)
 closed{-3.sg/-3.pl} many factories
 ‘Many factories closed.’
- (15) Ha {-Ø/ -n} venido muchos turistas este año. (Aragonese Spanish, Saura 2010:575)
 have {-3sg/-3pl} come much tourists this year
 ‘There {has/have} come many tourists this year.’
- (16) Ja entr {-a/ -en} clients. (North-Western Catalan, Rigau 2013:130)
 now enter{-3sg/-3pl} clients
 ‘Clients are coming in.’

Across many varieties of Romance, it is also possible to optionally realize agreement in specificational copular clauses under the same conditions as English: namely, with a postverbal third person plural argument DP. See the following examples in which both optional verbal agreement realizations have been confirmed as grammatical by native speakers from Spanish (Ordóñez p.c), Brazilian Portuguese (Quarezemin p.c), French (Batchelder-Schwab p.c), Asturian (Villa-García p.c), and Italian (De Santo p.c, Miatto p.c, Zompi p.c).

- (17) Lo que amo más en este mundo {es/son} los hombres guapos. (Spanish)
 it that love.1sg most in this world {is/ are} the men beautiful
 ‘What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.’
- (18) O que eu mais amo neste mundo {é/são} homens bonitos. (Brazilian Portuguese)
 it that I most love.1sg in.this world {is/are} men beautiful
 ‘What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.’

- (19) Ce que j'aime le plus dans ce monde {c'est/ce.sont} les beaux hommes. (French)
 this that love.1sg the most of this world {is/ are} the beautiful men
 'What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.'
- (20) Lo que más amu n'esti mundu {ye/son} los paisanos curiosos. (Asturian)
 it that most love.1sg in.this world {is/ are} the men curious
 'What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.'
- (21) Quello che amo di più al mondo {è/sono} gli uomini belli. (Italian)
 that that love.1sg of most to.the world {is/are} the men beautiful
 'What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.'

These data convincingly show that agreement optionality is borne out of a specific structural configuration that appears in a variety of contexts crosslinguistically. As these alternations are structural and systematic in nature, they lend themselves to a structural, systematic analysis. In the following section, I describe analysis of these agreement alternations that allows for optional number agreement to take place within a single set of parameters. This analysis is based in conditional, sequential cyclic probing driven by Minimal Search (Chomsky 2000; 2001).

Before the analysis is presented, I briefly defend in the following subsection the idea that these alternations should be thought of as cases of intraspeaker optionality within a single grammar.

2.2 Optional agreement within a single grammar

Rather than positing that these alternations unilaterally involve a speaker having access to multiple competing grammars (Kroch 1989; Embick 2007; Tortora 2014; Polinsky 2025), or that these alternations inherently involve speakers having access to multiple variations of a single lexical item (Adger 2006; Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008; Puškar 2017; Halpert 2019; Hoover 2021; Fernández-Serrano 2022; Driemel 2024; Streffer 2024, a.o), these alternations can actually be handled as optionality within a single grammatical system. That is, the alternations shown thus far can be sufficiently explained as a single set of grammatical operations operating over a single set of lexical items: in other words, we can handle the alternation within a single grammar and a single lexicon, which is indeed what is empirically supported, as I show in this section.

In order to place these alternations within a single grammatical system, let us consider the nature of the alternation itself. All the data presented in this section thus far involve an alternation in which verbal agreement morphology tracks a third person plural postverbal argument DP, or it shows up as third person singular (which here can be thought of as a kind of “default”). Take again the example in (1).

- (22) a. There were no problems with the analysis.
 b. There was no problems with the analysis.

While there is certainly a measurable difference in register between the (a) and (b) sentences here, it would not be accurate to claim that these sentences are each characteristic of different grammars that end up coexisting within a single speaker who accepts both variants. It is true that there are some English speakers who only accept agreement patterns of the (a) variety, but there

are no speakers who exclusively accept and produce the (b) pattern. As such, there is little independent empirical support for a grammar that only produces the (b) pattern.

Additionally, if it were the case that this alternation came about via the interaction of multiple grammars, then any instances of both patterns within a single utterance should be tantamount to code-switching. This does not seem to be ideal when considering the following examples, again taken from native English speakers' social media.

- (23)
- a. If there was problems at the turnstiles how is that Newcastle's problem!!! there were problems at their last game with away fans having the same problems.
 - b. If there are negative marks, then why isn't there grace marks?
 - c. If there are capital letters, why isn't there capital numbers?
 - d. If there was two shooters, which it now seems there were, then they both would not have missed Trump. Staged.
 - e. A reminder that there is two sides...There are two opposing vicious sides.

There is no obvious reason to think that these examples involve code-switching, and there is certainly no discernible difference in register within separate parts of these utterances. This is further corroborated by what we see with verbal coordination, in which there is an even further lack of evidence for code switching or difference in register between the two coordinated verbs, each showing a different agreement pattern. See the following examples from social media.

- (24)
- a. Though there was and are other locations in town, the Cordova location didn't last very long.
 - b. There is and always were cost effective alternatives.
 - c. There are and always was many Buddhas.
 - d. There were—and is—data on the mean or median costs of fraud by victim or offence.
 - e. There are and always has been many names for "God".

Similar examples can be found in certain varieties of Spanish (Storment 2025c), though I do not focus on them here.

These data in (23) and (24) suggest that it is not optimal to think of these cases of intraspeaker optionality as involving multiple grammars. Instead, it is more accurate to think of the difference between the agreeing and unagreeing patterns in terms of registers that constrain a single grammatical system: there is a register in which only the agreeing pattern (22a) is preferred, and there is another (perhaps lower) register in which both agreement variants are accepted.

As such, the analysis presented in this paper works within a single grammatical system to explain these cases of agreement optionality, which does not involve positing that multidialectalism is necessary to handle such alternations. This is not to say, however, that every single case of intraspeaker variation should be handled within a single grammar, as there are obviously other cases in clearly bidialectal speakers that involve intraspeaker variation that resembles code-switching between different dialects (e.g., between "standard" American English and African American English (Green 2002)), though it is not entirely clear that the literature on code-switching supports a view in which intraspeaker variation of any kind is best explained via a

language user maintaining and switching between two separate grammatical systems (MacSwan 1999; 2000; López 2020; Gosselin 2021; Lohndal & Putnam 2024a; b, a.o).

For these reasons, I lay out an analysis of the relevant alternation in the next section in terms of optionality within a single grammar that comes about as a result of the structural configurations in which this kind of optionality is commonly attested: namely, when a non-canonical phi-defective goal intervenes between an agreement probe and a non-defective DP goal.

3 Defective circumvention

The fact that both third person singular and third person plural verbal agreement morphology are possible in English existential *there* constructions with a third person plural associate (as well as in similar constructions as outlined in the previous section) is a natural consequence of this structural configuration as well as the nature of probing in phi-Agree, as I demonstrate now.

In the following subsection (3.1), I discuss the formal mechanism of Agree as defective circumvention that allows for both agreement patterns to obtain. I then (3.2) discuss how this agreement mechanism can be conditionally optional in terms of derivational economy principles.

3.1 Agree as Minimal Search

Here, I assume a standard Minimalist framework for Agree as defined in Chomsky (2000; 2001) in which probes—which bear unvalued phi-features—search for valued instances of the relevant features on a goal, which then get copied back to the probe (thus causing “valuation”). The main relevant piece of technology here is Minimal Search (henceforth *MS*), which I assume drives probing and a. ing in Agree operations (Chomsky 2013; Ke 2019; 2023) and is the means by which a probe searches for its closest relevant goal, with closeness being standardly defined in terms of asymmetrical c-command (Chomsky 2000). See the following definition of Agree.

- (25) *Agree* (Chomsky 2000:122)
- Agree is a syntactic operation taking place between a probe P and a goal G in the domain of P, D(P), between which a Matching relation holds.
- a. Matching is feature identity
 - b. D(P) is the sister of P
 - c. Locality reduces to “closest c-command”

I assume that phi-features are syntactic objects that are arranged in feature geometries that are present on both phi-probes and phi-goals, and that specific unvalued features within a geometric structure initiate searches (Harley & Ritter 2002; Béjar 2003; Preminger 2014, a.m.o). I additionally assume that feature copying is coarse in that a probe searching for a single feature within a geometric structure results in the entirety of the phi-feature geometry of the relevant goal being copied back to the probe (Preminger 2014; Coon & Keine 2021), which I believe is related to an idea from Béjar (2003:53) that Match is evaluated at the root node of a feature geometry in Agree operations.

Given these assumptions, let us return to the structure of the configurations outlined in Section 2. Descriptively, agreement optionality of this kind is associated with a configuration in which some kind of non-canonical material that is not marked for number (e.g., an existential expletive, a *wh*-cleft) appears in the structural subject position, along with a postverbal thematic subject

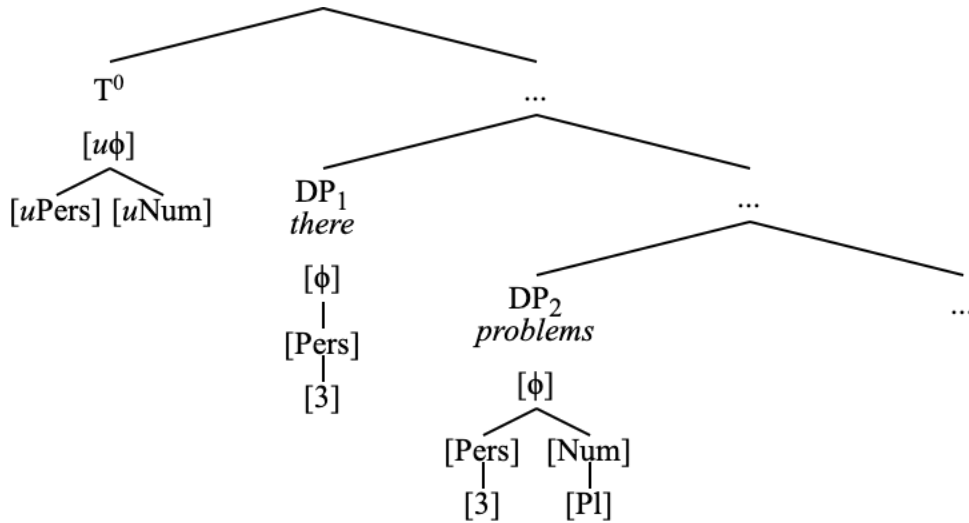
that is third person plural. We can straightforwardly analyze these situations as involving a phi-defective goal (i.e., the non-canonical structural subject) intervening between a phi-probe on T^0 —which is standardly taken to be the locus of subject-verb agreement—and a non-defective third person plural goal (i.e., the postverbal thematic subject). In other words, agreement optionality arises in these configurations because there are two accessible goals in the search domain of T^0 , the higher of which is phi-deficient.

The analysis of these intervening goals as being phi-deficient (I use the terms *defective* and *deficient* interchangeably here) follows from the precedent in the literature for analyzing existential *there* as lacking a number feature (Chomsky 1981; 2001; Béjar 2003:62; Deal 2009; Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022), which also has been claimed for *wh*-clefts (Krapp-López & Gravely 2024; Storment 2025b). Empirically, this is supported by the fact that neither existential *there* nor *wh*-clefts can be pluralized.

- (26) a. *Theres are birds in the trees.
b. *Whats I love most are beautiful men.

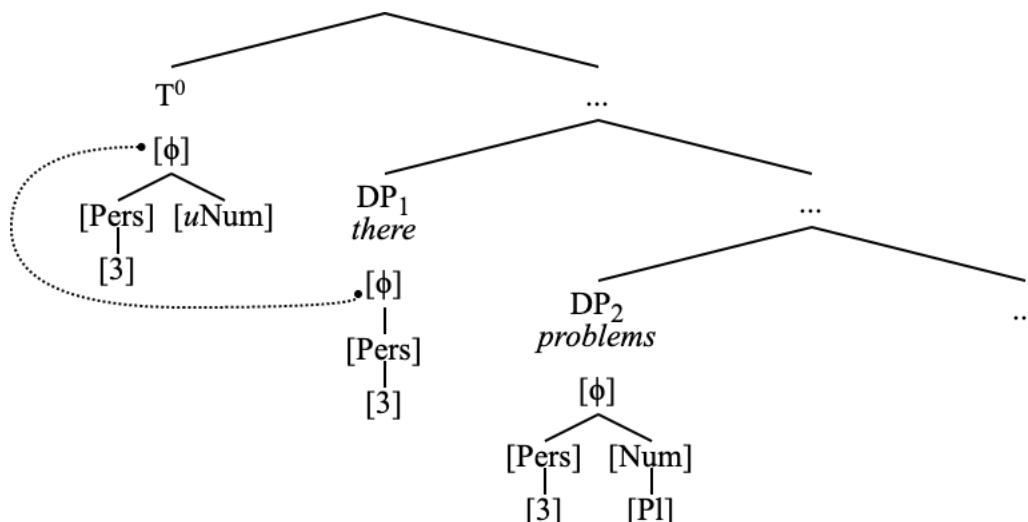
As such, these relevant configurations can be schematized as follows. I standardly assume that English T^0 searches for both person and number features (Béjar 2003; Béjar & Rezac 2009; Preminger 2014; Deal 2015; Kalin & van Urk 2015; Coon & Keine 2021, a.o), which I represent geometrically in the structure below.

- (27) There {was/were} problems.



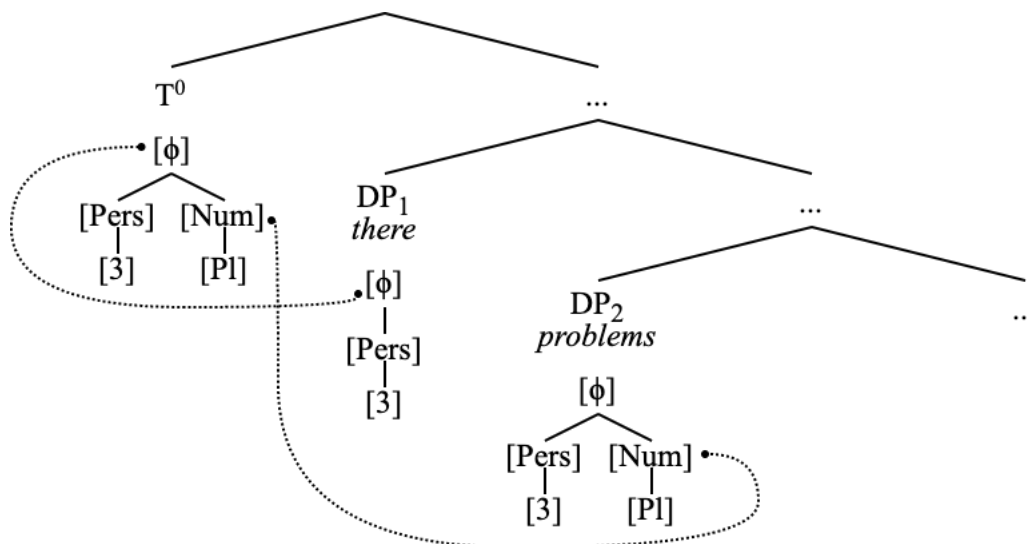
Here, when the feature geometry of the phi-probe on T^0 first probes for an element containing a valued feature $[\phi]$ (as it is the root node of a feature geometry that first initiates a search), the first element that it encounters bearing the feature $[\phi]$ is the goal *there* which lacks a number feature. I further assume that, in English, third person is distinctly represented as its own person feature (a discussion which I return to in Section 4). As such, probing of this higher goal results in the features $[\phi]$, $[\text{Pers}]$, and $[3]$ being copied back to the probe. As a result, we arrive at the following derivation.

(28) There {was/were} problems: T^0 valued for person, not number.



At this point, the derivation has two choices (the optionality of which I expound upon in the following subsection). The probe can halt all searches at this point, with its unvalued number feature remaining, and thus spell out third person singular “default” subject-verb agreement. Additionally, the probe has the option to initiate a second search for its unvalued number feature. If the probe takes the latter option, then it results in agreement with the postverbal DP, given that the postverbal DP is in the search domain of T^0 (i.e., that there is no intervening phase boundary between T^0 and the farther goal). See the following.

(29) There {was/were} problems: T^0 valued for both person and number.



Above in (29), the probe has acquired features from two distinct goals, copying back the entirety of the feature geometries of each goal, due to the coarseness of feature copying. This only results in a licit derivation if the features of the two goals accumulated on the probe are compatible with one another. By this, I mean that they must stand in a subset-superset relation with one another.

For instance, in (29), the set of features of the higher goal $\{[\phi], [\text{Pers}], [3]\}$ is a proper subset of the set of features of the lower goal $\{[\phi], [\text{Pers}], [3], [\text{Num}], [\text{Pl}]\}$. If these features were not in this subset-superset relation, it would create issues for interpretation and spellout, which I expound upon in Section 4, though this is not an issue for the derivation shown in (29).

The considerations on the derivation shown above, whereby Multiple Agree driven by MS can conditionally obtain with two goals in the search domain of T^0 , can be summarized by the following generalization, known as defective circumvention.

(30) *Defective Circumvention* (Storment 2025b)

A probe P enters into an Agree relation with a higher ϕ -deficient goal α and then conditionally goes on to Agree past α with a lower, more featurally-specified goal β , given that the features of α and β are not incompatible with one another.

- a. Agree without defective circumvention $\rightarrow$ “Default” (3sg) agreement
- b. Agree with defective circumvention $\rightarrow$ Agreement with postverbal DP

Defective circumvention, then, refers to the process by which agreement with the postverbal subject obtains, as in (29). Defective intervention as shown for the examples discussed so far is an optional process that can be carried out or not, though there are cases still in which defective circumvention is obligatory, and other cases in which it results in an illicit derivation, and is thus functionally impossible. I discuss these cases in the following section (4), after discussing how exactly a process such as this can be optional within a given derivation in Section 3.2.

3.2 Optionality and economy

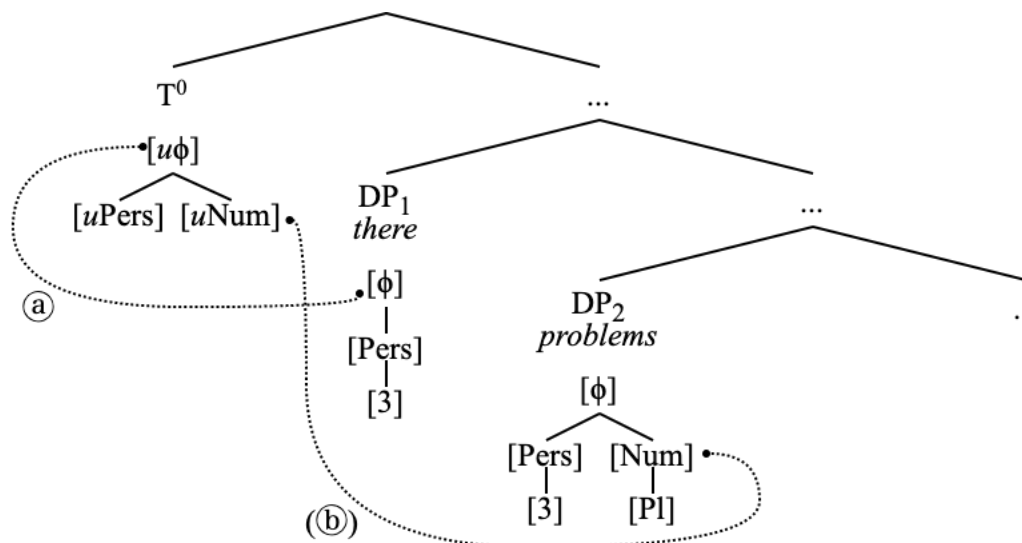
Crucially, the second cycle of probing for defective circumvention in (30) must be optional in the cases outlined above, which may initially seem puzzling as probing in Agree is typically understood to be obligatory in any environment where it is possible (Preminger 2014). It must be the case, then, that probing for the feature $[\text{Num}]$ (number) is optional in such a way that probing for $[\phi]$ probing is not. This ability to not obligatorily probe for number appears related to the fact that, in a feature-geometric structure, the presence of number asymmetrically entails the presence of a $[\phi]$ feature (i.e., we can find constituents which bear $[\phi]$ and not $[\text{Num}]$, but not the other way around). It seems better, then, to say that probing of a root node in a geometric structure (e.g., $[\phi]$) is obligatory—which is not incompatible with the proposals of Preminger (2014) and seems to be corroborated elsewhere (e.g., Béjar 2003)—while the conditions on probing of non-root nodes may parametrically vary.

Ultimately, the fact that number agreement probing can be optional (given that it is not obligatory) within a single derivation can be thought of in terms of general economy conditions in the grammar (Collins 1997; Chomsky 2001; 2024). It is generally understood and accepted that syntactic derivations act in their best economic interest: that is, when faced with the “decision” to perform to carry out a given operation or not, it will “behave” in accordance with which outcome is the most derivationally economical (i.e., what is less costly for the computational system). This principle explains the optionality that arises in the examples discussed thus far.

Regarding defective circumvention (30), the two options that these relevant derivations are faced with—to probe a second time for number, or not to probe a second time—are equally

uneconomical in that both derivational paths represent a costly operation in the grammar. Let us return to the derivation in (29), reschematized below.

(31) There {was/were} problems.



In this view, the probe just performing one search (a) and not undergoing defective circumvention means that some work will have to be done at interfaces to assign a default value to the unvalued number feature: see technology Partial Default Agreement (PDA) of Béjar (2003) and similar mechanisms (e.g., Fernández-Serrano 2022) which have been proposed to handle the issue of assigning a value to an unvalued feature at transfer. In this way, dealing with the “leftover” unvalued number feature on the probe is costly for the derivation as it requires the invocation of some mechanism that would not otherwise be necessary.

Alternatively, if the probe does perform defective circumvention and probes a second time (b), carrying out a new search is also costly for the grammar. In more canonical cases of subject-verb agreement with a subject DP, the probe only has to search once for its features to be valued, as most canonical subject DPs are not deficient for number. Straightforwardly, a probe initiating multiple searches is more costly for the derivation than if it only had to carry out a single search.

As such, the grammar arrives hereat a sort of derivational economic fork in the road, where it is faced with two options, neither of which is more economical than the other since each option must involve the performance of a costly additional step. It is this scenario that gives rise to the optionality between singular and plural agreement in situations where a noncanonical number-deficient structural subject appears along with a third person plural postverbal subject DP.

The derivation in (31) give rise to optionality because the lack of full satisfaction of economy conditions as described here, and because not doing defective circumvention (leading to singular agreement) and doing defective circumvention (thereby causing plural agreement) both result in a licit derivation. Without defective circumvention, there is simply no valued number feature on T^0 , which in the end is not an issue that results in a derivation to fail (Preminger 2014). When defective circumvention occurs with a postverbal third person plural DP, as shown above, the

result is grammatical as the features on the probe acquired from the first goal are not incompatible with the features of the second goal. This is not predicted to be the case in every single derivation where defective circumvention has the possibility to occur, though.

In the following section, I show cases in which the licit outputs of defective circumvention are constrained by the featural makeup of the probes and goals in the derivations, effectively eliminating the optionality seen in the examples discussed here thus far.

4 Defective circumvention without optionality

There are cases still in which the availability of defective circumvention does not lead to agreement optionality. In some cases, depending on the featural makeup of the relevant phi-probe and its goals, undergoing defective circumvention leads to an illicit derivation due to the accumulation of incompatible features on the probe. Here, I discuss the impossibility of agreement with first and second person ([Part]-bearing) postverbal subjects in configuration that allow optional defective circumvention with third person plural postverbal subjects (4.1).

In other cases, not doing defective circumvention leads to an illicit derivation due to independently motivated licensing conditions on certain relativized features that may be present on a given probe, which is determined parametrically. As an example of this, I discuss cases in Spanish where agreement is obligatory with a [Part]-bearing postverbal subject, despite optional agreement being allowed with a third person plural postverbal subject (4.2).

4.1 Weak PCC effects in English

In contemporary colloquial English, while it is possible to have agreement optionally realized with third person plural postverbal subjects in a variety of configurations, there is no such optionality with [Part]-bearing postverbal subjects in the same configurations. Contrast the examples in (32) with those in (33).

- (32) a. There {was/were} problems.
b. What I love most in this world {is/are} beautiful men.
- (33) a. There {was/*were} you.
b. What you love most in this world {is/*am} {me/*I}.

Indeed, the ungrammaticality of agreement holds with plural [Part]-bearing postverbal subjects as well.

- (34) a. There {was/*were} y'all.
b. What you love most in this world {is/*are} {us/*we}.

Storment (2025b) demonstrates this contrast for other constructions such as quotative and locative inversion. The author's judgments confirm this contrast as well.

It may initially be tempting to claim that agreement with the postverbal subjects in (33) and (34) is not possible because the subjects are marked with accusative Case, thus explaining this contrast in terms of "Case-discriminating" probing (Bobaljik 2008; Preminger 2014, a.o). This

would be problematic, however, because the same agreement optionality seen with third person plural non-pronominal postverbal DPs—which do not show Case distinctions—as in (32) is also readily available with third person plural accusative pronominal DPs (i.e., *them*).

- (35) a. There {was/were} them.
b. What I love most in this world {is/are} them.

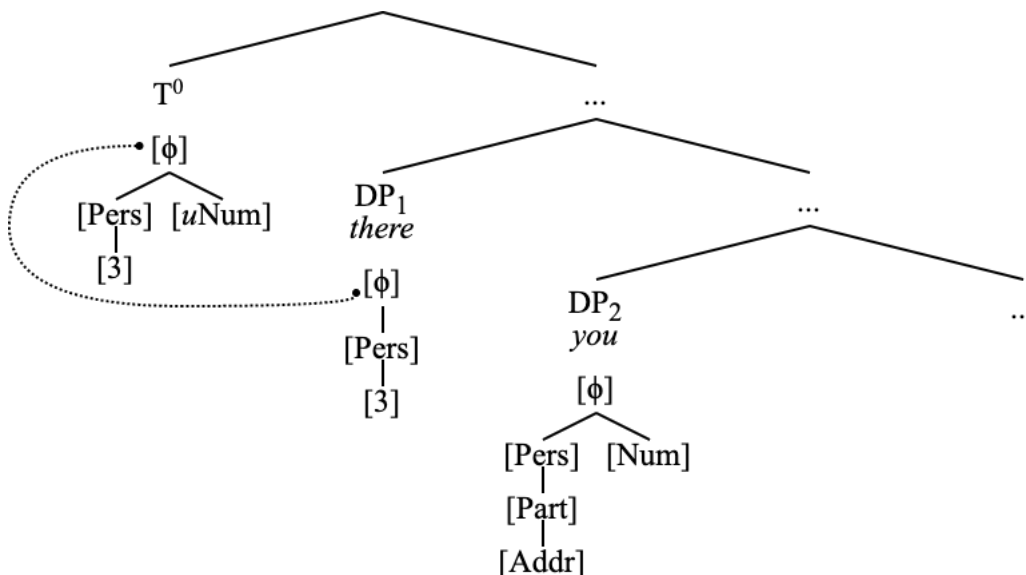
The grammaticality of both singular and plural agreement in colloquial English in (35) is empirically supported with data from social media. The grammaticality of third person plural verbal agreement with a postverbal *them* in existential *there* sentences is specifically supported elsewhere in the literature (Francez 2006; Deal 2009). See the following Internet examples.

- (36) a. There are them that cannot sing, and them that cannot weep. (Storment 2025b:48)
b. There are them and then there's #ME !
c. There were them and there was us; and he never ever saw it any differently.
d. What their families really need are them.
e. Honestly the only thing about muncie that i'll miss are them.

These data significantly complicate a view in which accusative Case blocks agreement probing by T^0 . Instead of saying that the DPs in (33) and (34) cannot be agreed with by T^0 because they are marked accusative, it is better to claim that these DPs are marked accusative because they have not been agreed with by T^0 , thus supporting a classic view of Case assignment as agreement with a functional head (Chomsky 2000; 2001). Here, I show how the impossibility of agreement with a [Part]-bearing postverbal DP in English is explained by defective circumvention.

Take the example from (33a). For the probe undergoing agreement with the preverbal existential expletive *there*, this process works exactly the same as it does in (28). As such, we end up with the following derivation, in which the features of the existential are valued on the probe.

- (37) There {was/*were} you: T^0 valued for person, not number.



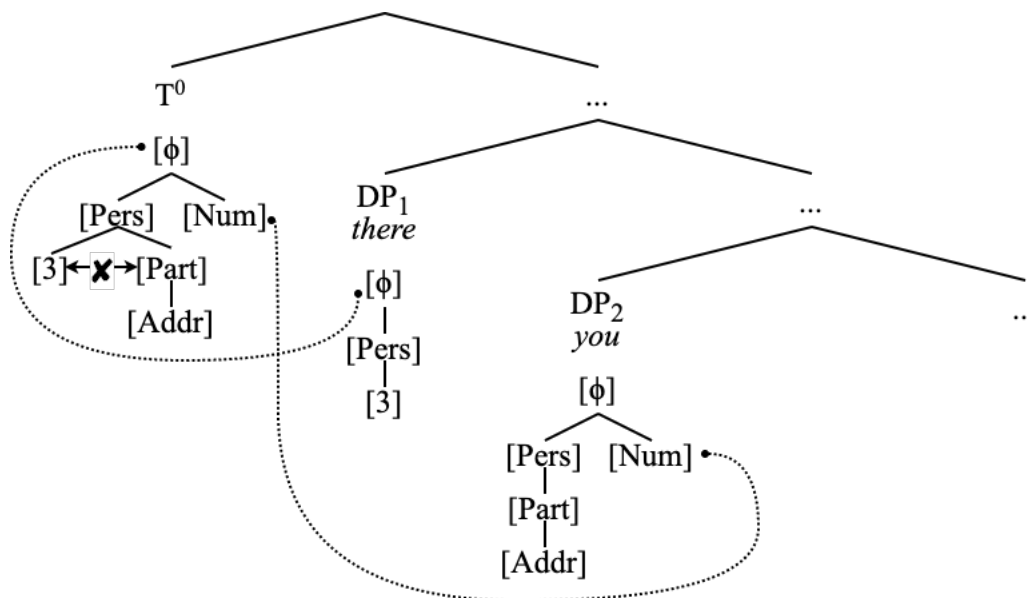
At this point, the derivation has the option to stop probing, which will lead to third person singular verbal agreement morphology. If the derivation takes this route, there are no significant problems incurred by the derivation that would lead to ungrammaticality, just as was the case with third person plural postverbal associates.

If the probe were to initiate a second search for defective circumvention, however, there would be issues. Recall that defective circumvention only leads to a licit derivation if the features of the higher goal are a proper subset of the features of the lower goal. We must again assume here that third person is distinctly featurally represented in English (i.e., that English is a “3yesP” language (Nevins 2007)), which Béjar (2003:48) notes must be a point of crosslinguistic variation, and which is corroborated by the fact third person “invisibility” (in the sense of Grishin 2023) does not seem to hold in English for processes such as present tense *-s* insertion (Storment 2025b:97).

We must further assume that a third person feature [3] and a participant feature [Part] are not compatible within the same feature geometry. One potential objection to this assumption is that first person exclusive forms and meanings may perhaps come about from the presence of a third person feature and a first person feature within the same geometry. I reject such an analysis here on the grounds that, while first person inclusive forms are typically analyzed as containing both a speaker and a participant feature, it is standard to analyze first person exclusive forms as containing only a speaker feature (Harley & Ritter 2002; Béjar 2003; Nevins 2007; Harbour 2016; Bobaljik & Sauerland 2023). While it is plausible to maintain compatibility between a [Speaker] and [Addressee] feature within a single geometry, one must wonder what it would even mean for a geometry to contain both a [Participant] (either [Speaker] or [Addressee]) feature and a third person (that is, a non-participant feature) feature within a single referring expression. Empirically, these claims are supported by the fact that there exist languages for which first person inclusive forms contain unambiguously second person morphology (e.g., Guaraní (Estigarribia 2020; Johnson 2024)), but there are no languages for which first person exclusive forms contain overtly third person morphology. As such, I maintain the view here that [3] and [Part] person features are not simultaneously licensed within a single feature-geometric structure for issues of interpretability at interfaces.

Given these considerations, the probe’s possible second search for a number feature, thus leading to defective circumvention, leads to the presence of two incompatible person features within a single feature geometry on the probe.

(38) There {was/*were} you: T^0 valued for person (incompatibility) and number.



Now, the probe on T^0 has acquired features from two goals, but the features of the higher goal do not form a proper subset of the features of the lower goal: $\{[\phi], [\text{Pers}], [3]\} \not\subseteq \{[\phi], [\text{Pers}], [\text{Part}], [\text{Addr}], [\text{Num}]\}$. This culmination of incompatible features within a single probe leads to interpretive issues at interfaces, and thus the derivation is not licit.

What this means for defective circumvention is that the optional step to perform defective circumvention in these cases leads to an ungrammatical derivation. Thus, the only option that leads to a licit derivation is for the probe to not initiate a search for number after undergoing Agree with the higher, deficient argument. This leads to the only grammatical verbal agreement pattern with a $[\text{Part}]$ -bearing postverbal subject in the relevant constructions is third person singular agreement morphology.

What we see here is a class of weak PCC effects, in which agreement with a lower $[\text{Part}]$ -bearing DP is blocked by the presence of a higher third person DP (Coon & Keine 2021). Here, I have described a weak-PCC configuration involving English multiple subject constructions, contributing to the literature on PCC effects with multiple subjects (Coon & Keine & Wagner 2017) and showing that PCC effects exist in English as well. These examples and their analysis of them using sequential Multiple Agree as Minimal Search opens the door for other cases of PCC effects—such as those with multiple object clitics in Romance—to be analyzed in the same way.

4.2 Obligatory $[\text{Part}]$ agreement in Spanish

Turning now to yet another pattern, we see in Spanish that the same optional alternation exists for many speakers in many varieties of Spanish across different domains. See examples (9), (13), (15), and (17). Focusing on just one of these examples, the dative experiencer subject construction (Fernández-Serrano 2022), take the following example.

- (39) Me gusta{-Ø/ -n} los libros de sintaxis.
 me.DAT like {-3sg/-3pl} the books of syntax
 ‘I like books about syntax.’

Like English, whenever the postverbal thematic subject DP is first or second person, the optional agreement seen in (39) disappears. Unlike English, however, the only viable option is to spell out verbal agreement that matches the features of the postverbal [Part]-bearing DP.

- (40) Me gusta{-s/ *-Ø} tú.
 me.DAT like {-2sg/*-3sg} you.NOM
 ‘I like you.’

- (41) Te gusta{-mos/*-Ø} nosotros.
 you.DAT like {-1pl/ *-3sg} we
 ‘You like us.’

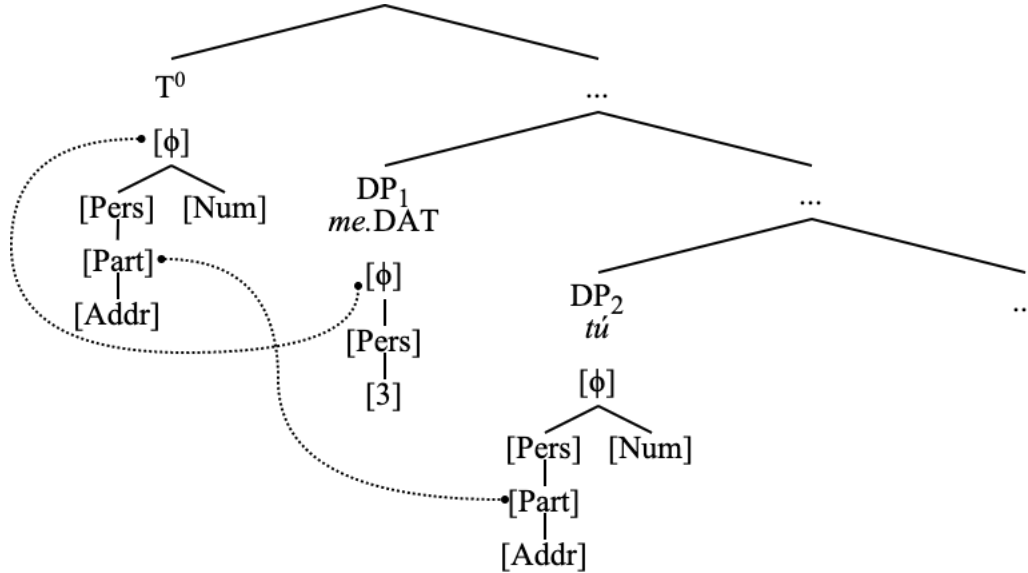
There are two aspects of this difference between Spanish and English to explain here. First, defective circumvention probing of the lower [Part]-bearing goal in Spanish does not lead to an illicit derivation. Second, not only is agreement with the lower [Part]-bearing goal permitted in Spanish, it is the only viable option, as third singular default agreement is not grammatical.

Regarding the first point, recall that defective circumvention with a [Part]-bearing lower goal in English leads to an illicit derivation due to the accumulation of incompatible person features on the probe: a third person non-participant feature from the higher deficient goal, and a participant feature from the lower goal. This comes about because of the fact that English is a “3yesP” language in which third person features are distinctly represented.

In a language where third person is not distinctly represented (a “3noP” language (Nevins 2007)), however, third person is represented as a deficient person value: there is no [3] feature, third person interpretations are just derived by the presence of a person feature [Pers] without a more specific [Part] feature appearing below it. In “3noP” languages, then, third person features are a subset of first/second person features: {[Pers]} $\subset$ {[Pers], [Part]}. Thus, defective circumvention can obtain with a [Part]-bearing postverbal DP without incompatibility in a language in which third person is deficiently represented. It follows, then, that Spanish should be one of these languages, which is empirically corroborated by the fact that third person forms often correspond to zero or default forms, such as in verbal agreement and pronominal paradigms.

In examples (40) and (41), then, defective circumvention does not produce the incompatibility on the probe that is seen with [Part]-agreement in the relevant English examples because of the deficient representation of third person in Spanish, keeping in mind that dative subjects are visible to the phi-probe on T⁰ as number-deficient third person elements (Rezac 2004; 2008; Bjorkman & Zeijlstra 2019; Fernández-Serrano 2022, a.o) See below.

- (42) Me gustas tú ‘You like me’: Defective circumvention probing.



As for the second point above, it must be the case that the option to not do defective circumvention in these cases leads to an illicit structure, as third person singular agreement is not a viable agreement option in these examples. I explain this fact in terms of the parametric difference in having an unvalued [Part] feature present on the phi-probe on T^0 , which has been claimed independently for Spanish (Gravely & Krapp-López & Greeson 2025). I relate the presence of this probe to the Person Licensing Condition (PLC), which states that 1st/2nd person features must enter into a valuation relation (Béjar & Rezac 2003; Baker 2008; Preminger 2014; Raynaud 2020, a.o) for reasons of discourse licensing, which effectively means that [Part]-probing is obligatory in a way that [Num]-probing is not.

- (43) *Person Licensing Condition* (Béjar & Rezac 2003:53)
Interpretable 1st/2nd-person features must be licensed by entering into an Agree relation with an appropriate functional category.

While Béjar & Rezac (2003) present the PLC as an axiom, and it has been framed as a universal condition on all participant features crosslinguistically (Nichols 2001; Ormazabal & Romero 2001), it is clear when comparing the English and Spanish data presented in this paper that agreement with a [Part] feature by T^0 cannot be universally necessary in every language. For this reason, I relate the necessity of [Part]-agreement as stated in the PLC to the presence of a participant probe (see also Preminger 2011:931; Coon & Keine 2021:611), which may parametrically be present or absent in a given language. Defective circumvention with [Part]-bearing postverbal subjects in Spanish, then, is driven by an obligatory search for a participant feature, as opposed to an optional search for a number feature.

Ultimately, I believe that this [Part] probe being available in Spanish but not English can be related to the null subject parameter, since the [+Pronominal] T^0 in Spanish (Rizzi 1982) is relativized to more robustly express person feature values than T^0 in English.

Thus, the obligatory [Part]-agreement in Spanish cases where third person plural agreement is optional is explained in terms of the deficiency of Spanish third person (i.e., Spanish being a “3noP” language) along with the fact that Spanish T⁰ bears an unvalued participant feature which must obligatorily search for a matching goal. We can contrast this situation with the English [Part]-agreement examples in section 4.1, in which the distinct “3yesP” representation of third person along with the fact that English T⁰ does not trigger obligatory searches for participant features leads to the impossibility of agreement with a [Part]-bearing goal in these configurations.

This analysis predicts further combinations of these parametric settings, such as a language in which third person features are deficiently represented and there is no obligatory participant probing, which means that agreement with a [Part]-bearing lower goal does not create a featural incompatibility on the probe and defective circumvention agreement with the [Part]-bearing goal would be optionally driven by the probe’s unvalued number feature. In this language, we expect to see optional agreement with postverbal third person plural DPs as well as [Part]-bearing DPs, which seems to be attested for Brazilian Portuguese.

- (44) Cheg {-ou/ -aram} as cadeiras. (Costa 2000:8)
 arrived{-3sg/-3pl} the chairs
 ‘There arrived the chairs.’

- (45) Cheg {-ou/ -uei} eu. (Silveira 2021:11)
 arrived{-3sg/-1sg} I.NOM
 ‘There arrived me.’

We would also expect to see a “3yesP” language in which third person features are deficiently represented, and there is also obligatory [Part]-probing driven by an unvalued participant feature on T⁰. In such a situation, agreement with a third person plural postverbal subject is predicted to be optional, while the presence of a [Part]-bearing postverbal subject should lead to ungrammaticality, whether or not it is agreed with, since not agreeing with it would fail to satisfy the PLC and agreeing with it would lead to a featural incompatibility on the probe. This seems to be the case in Icelandic dative subject configurations.

- (46) Henni {líkaði/ líkuðu} þeir. (Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008:260)
 her.DAT {like.3sg/like.3pl} they.NOM
 ‘She likes them.’

- (47) *Henni {líkaði/ líkum} við. (Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008:254)
 her.DAT {like.3sg/like.1pl} we.NOM
 int: ‘She likes us

Though the facts are certainly more complicated for Portuguese and Icelandic than what I present here (e.g., I do not venture to explain how syncretic agreement forms can apparently improve the ungrammaticality of an Icelandic example such as (47) (Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008)), we can take these examples and arrive at the following crosslinguistic paradigm.

(48) Constraining factors on defective circumvention by language

	“3yesP”	“3noP”
<i>[_Part] probe</i>	Icelandic	Spanish
<i>No [_Part] probe</i>	English	Br. Port.

I leave a detailed review of the Brazilian Portuguese and Icelandic facts for future work. What is clear here is that optional agreement in all of these cases can be derived via optional number probing via defective circumvention, while [Part]-agreement via defective circumvention is parametrically constrained by a number of factors including the featural representation of third person and the presence of a participant probe on the relevant probing head. Depending on how these factors are represented, one could have: a lack of optionality in [Part]-agreement where the only option is to not do defective circumvention, as in English; a lack of optionality in [Part]-agreement where the only option is to do defective circumvention, as in Spanish; optional defective circumvention with a [Part]-bearing goal, as in Brazilian Portuguese; or, a situation in which the conditions for [Part]-agreement can never be satisfied in a defective circumvention configuration, as in Icelandic. Crucially, though, in all of these languages, agreement with a postverbal third person plural DP is always optional.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, I have shown that complex agreement interaction effects involving optional agreement, PCC effects, and obligatory participant probing can all be accounted for under a system of conditional, sequential Multiple Agree as Minimal Search known as defective circumvention, in which a probe may conditionally probe past a phi-deficient goal to undergo Agree with a further, phi-complete goal, after having already undergone Agree with the deficient goal. In this framework, optional agreement with certain postverbal subjects can be accounted for within a single grammatical system (Saab 2025), thus removing the need to stipulate multiple grammars or multiple lexicons for every single instance of intraspeaker variation.

Though optional agreement may obtain in cases where economy conditions allow defective circumvention to be performed optionally, there are cases still in which defective circumvention may be constrained by the featural makeup of the relevant probes and goals in a given derivation where defective circumvention is possible. The crosslinguistic variation of such features can lead to the impossibility of agreement with certain goals, as I have shown with English [Part]-bearing postverbal subjects; alternatively, it can lead to obligatory agreement with the same goals, as I have shown for Spanish. This work recontextualizes discussions of weak PCC effects as well as obligatory participant probing and the Person Licensing Condition, showing that all of these phenomena can be naturally explained with an account of probing as Minimal Search.

This system of defective circumvention and how it is parameterized also bears relevance for other agreement interaction effects with postverbal subjects crosslinguistically. Though I do not show it here, I believe that this framework will be fruitful in explaining phenomena such as obligatory gender agreement and number disagreement with postverbal subjects in Arabic (Fassi Fehri 1993; Harbert & Bahloul 2002) as well as conditional multiple nominative Case assignment in Tshila (Storment 2025a). I leave detailed explanations of such examples as open cases for future work which takes place within this framework.

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